to prevent misunderstanding, increasing the Taliban's political value was deemed unnecessary. Moreover, silent engagement suited both India and the Afghan Taliban. It assured Indian officials that the Taliban would not develop hostility against India, and mitigated risks for Afghan Taliban leaders who worried that open linkages with India would land them into trouble with Pakistan.

India was not inhibited about the idea of reconciliation with or reintegration of the Afghan Taliban per se. What concerned Indian policymakers was the way in which the coalition forces, especially the UK and the US, were going about it; seemingly at Karzai's expense, and allowing Taliban hardliners to determine the terms of negotiations. New Delhi desired an Afghan-led and Afghan-owned reconciliation without external interference. This meant that Karzai would set the terms of talks and not the Afghan Taliban or, especially, Pakistan. However, a grim security scenario, the Kabul government's structural and systemic shortcomings (corruption and cronyism being some of the many), Pakistan's determination to continue with an interventionist Afghanistan policy, and the coalition forces' military exhaustion coupled with political disinterest in Afghanistan, made Afghan-led reconciliation highly unfeasible. In a scenario where Pakistan-supported groups were influencing the terms of reconciliation, contacts with the Afghan Taliban, India calculated, would also insure against the risk of potential disintegration of the Afghan state. Plus, the Afghan Taliban's support was a prerequisite to develop economic connectivity (oil and gas pipelines) with Central Asia. The cost-benefit analysis of talking to the Taliban was similar to what India faced in late 1980s when Najibullah was secretly engaging with different Mujahideen factions. In early 2006, Karzai himself had started to secretly engage with certain Taliban figures in an attempt to lure them away (or liberate them) from the 'clutches' of the ISI.

In this context, and given India's own outreach to Pakistan, on 15 May 2006 Fazlur Rahman, a Taliban ideologue, landed in Delhi for a four-day visit. He was to be the guest-of-honour at a reception hosted by the Deobandi political organisation, the Jamiat-i-Ulama-i-Hind (JuH). Though failing to attract many Indian Muslim clerics, the JuH had convinced former Indian foreign minister Natwar Singh and former J&K chief minister Farooq Abdullah to join the reception. Little reported by the English language press, India's Urdu press